

Price Watch

Find out the latest prices of laptops, iPod docks and graphics cards

Killer Rigs

Want to build a new rig and confused about what components to get? Read on...



LENS CONUNDRUM

Which glass best suits your needs and your budget?

Agent 001

agent001@thinkdigit.com

It's happened very often, that when people look at an amazing photo, their first response/question is "Wow! You must have an awesome camera / Wow! What camera did you use?" Lenses get very little credit for the "awesome photograph" and I really do wish people would realize just how important these tubes of glass really are. They are the eye that let the camera see what it sees. If your eye is weak, you can't see well and just like that, the quality of the lens you're using makes a world of a difference. You could have the best camera on the planet, but if you're using a crap lens, you can expect to get VERY few optically perfect shots.

There are basically a few things to consider when you buy lenses

1) Know What You're going to Shoot

Time and again, people say "I want to shoot everything!" Well, that's not an option. There is no "one-lens-to-rule-them-all", meaning, that no one lens can appease every photographic need. Generally the 18-200 kind of superzoom lenses work as great

walk-around lenses, but they won't give you much when it comes to fast apertures. The same way, you can't have a lens that has a fast aperture AND is a superzoom.

2) How to choose the lens?

If you're going to be shooting a lot of landscape, 18 mm is just not enough. A lens with a 10 or 12 mm focal length on the wide range is ideal. For portrait work lenses with a larger focal length and a smaller aperture number (like f/2.8 or f/1.8) work best. Fast aperture lenses also help a lot if you're ever caught off guard shooting in a low light situation.

3) Front Element Matters

One of the most overlooked fact about lenses is their front element. They are the primary collectors of light for the lens and thus, the bigger they are, the most light your lens will gather, effectively yielding faster shutter speeds. The shutter speeds get even better the wider the focal length on the lens becomes.

4) To IS or NOT to IS?

Image Stabilization helps produce

images free from the blur caused by camera shake and as a feature it is becoming increasingly pervasive through the lens ecosystem. Recently, there was a 28 mm lens announced with IS and I just thought to myself "why?". The rule for avoiding camera shake is that your shutter speed should be equal to or greater than 1/focal length. So if you're shooting at 200 mm, your shutter speed should ideally be 1/200th of a second to avoid any camera shake. As long as you follow this rule, you won't need IS. However, I would strongly recommend buying lenses with IS If your focal length is 150 mm or higher.

5) You Get What You Pay For

Now that you know what you're going to shoot, and you've identified the more or less ideal lens for it, don't cheap out. The more expensive alternative of a lens is expensive because of the quality of the glass used along with the excellent coatings on them. This isn't to say that the cheaper lenses aren't good performers, but lenses are an investment and it makes sense to invest in something that is the best. Lenses can last forever, not your camera. 